“The LeBlanc family liked you both. And they’re grateful for all the work you did. I hope you’ll come again.”

“It’s just you and Monsieur LeBlanc picking all those grapes?”

“Yes. He says the warm and dry weather has given us more time; we’ve probably got two more weeks until we finish.”

A whistle came from across the street, and they turned to see a man signaling to them.

“The movie is starting,” André said. “Shall we?”

He reached for her hand, filling Rose with a yearning she’d never known. It was as if she’d always been observing life through a glass door, never experiencing its warmth firsthand. But now André stood at the door, holding it open. Even if she and Léa hadn’t sorted out where they would move to and Léa had yet to find a job, Rose wasn’t troubled like she would have been before. André gently squeezed her palm, and she felt like the luckiest woman in the world.

Inside the cinema, the screen’s light flickered over the red velvet seats. A few couples sat farther up; the cinema was less than half full. André held her hand as they took seats in the last row near the exit. A black-and-white newsreel played, covering Germany’s advance into Russia and a Japanese offensive in Guadalcanal.

She turned to him. “Gua . . . dal . . . canal?”

“An island in the Pacific Ocean,” he whispered, bringing her hand to his lips, giving it a gentle kiss.

As Rose watched the film, she found it hard to follow the action. Sensations coursed through her. André’s touch was cool and sensual like bath water—comfort, joy, surprise. Did he feel it too? She wanted to remember every detail so later she could tell Léa.

On the screen, the tugboat captain stood alone on the beach. Rose didn’t know what had happened to the two women in his life, but suddenly they were gone. Relaxed and at ease, she leaned on André’s shoulder and closed her eyes.

“Are you tired? We can go early.” His voice was like a warm breeze on her cheek.

She lifted her head and gazed into his eyes. His mouth opened, and their lips met. They kissed—cautious and tender—and a thousand spidery threads spun through every part of Rose’s body. She gave up to him